

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 25 AUGUST 2026



THE FACT THAT GOLD QUICKENS IN A PRICE TICK UP · THE SLAB OF GRADE THAT HOLDS ITS VALUE

Gold clears a fresh record and the Treasury rescues its own long bond a second time — the debasement trade runs into a new Fed chair's first Friday

July inflation runs to a near-two-year high — and yet the print came in soft, because the cause is a switch at the meter, not the economy

Film photography, where a light-proof roll and a decades-old camera become an obsession — and the community itself calls the point-and-shoot prices madness

Twelve Desks · One World

Source: Wikimedia Commons — "File:400-oz-Gold-Bars-AB-01.jpg" (Andrzej Barabasz / Chepry, CC BY-SA 4.0). Four-hundred-ounce good-delivery gold bars — the hard asset a record price, a bond scare and a Vietnamese savings rush all circle this issue. Representative image, honestly labelled.

THIS ISSUE · THE WEEKDAY BOOK

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FROM THE DESK

"Gold is money. Everything else is credit."

— J. Pierpont Morgan, distilled from his testimony to the U.S. House "Pujo" Committee on the money trust, December 1912¹

Morgan's line is the thread running through this issue. Gold cleared a fresh record this week as a nineteen-year high in the long bond forced the Treasury to rescue its own market, and the debasement bid lit up bullion and bitcoin alike (p14). Half a world away, young Vietnamese are voting the same way with their salaries — buying gold by the tenth-of-a-*tael* as a private pension, just as their government races to pull that hoard into a formal exchange (p21). And the instinct scales down to the smaller desks: a bed sheet chosen for the cloth rather than the logo (p6), a camera bought once and kept for decades (p15). When the credit looks shaky, people reach for the thing they can hold.

THE STRIP — AT MONDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	24 AUG
VWRA	193.30
US 10-Year	~4.72%
US 30-Year	~5.23%
DXY	~98.7
USD/SGD	1.2781
USD/JPY	158.9
Brent	~\$92
Gold (XAU)	~\$4,640
Bitcoin	~\$78k

Levels ~Mon 24 Aug close; STI near its 5,774 record (11 Aug). Arrows vs No. 81. Market data, not advice.

THE WEEK AHEAD — WHAT'S WORTH WATCHING

Today, Tue 25 Aug. Garmin's "Play Harder" livestream is expected to unveil the Fēnix 9 and Enduro 4 adventure watches — the day's buy-once gear drop (p9). Singapore's July inflation print has landed (p5).

Wed 26 Aug. Nvidia reports, having guided to about ninety-one billion dollars — the tape's single biggest read on whether the AI build-out's cash still covers its capex (p7).

Fri 28 Aug. The new Fed chair, Kevin Warsh, gives his first Jackson Hole keynote into a market pricing a hold — and, at the tail, a hike, not a cut (p14).

Around 28 Aug. Z.ai's GLM-5.3 open weights are due to publish, two weeks after a launch the lab held back over the model's own hacking ability (p7).

A forward-looking guide, not a prediction. Scoreable calls are logged and graded on Saturdays.

SOURCES 1. J. Pierpont Morgan, testimony to the U.S. House Committee on Banking and Currency (the "Pujo" money-trust hearings), December 1912; the widely-cited distillation of his exchange with Samuel Untermyer ("Money is gold, and nothing else"). Market levels ~Mon 24 Aug 2026 close (CNBC / Trading Economics / Investing.com / Fortune), held pending clean terminal prints; arrows are direction vs No. 81.

THE WORLD • AMMAN & DAMASCUS

For the First Time Since the War, Syria and Israel Sit Down to Turn the Strikes Off

On Sunday a Syrian delegation led by the foreign minister — and, tellingly, both intelligence chiefs — met Israel's Mossad director in Jordan under American mediation. On the table: a "special operations room" to stop the shooting, and the security deal the two sides had almost signed before the wider war blew it up.

this story  

The most consequential meeting of the week was one almost no one saw. On Sunday, in Jordan and under American supervision, Syria's foreign-affairs chief Asaad al-Shaibani sat across from Roman Gofman, the head of Israel's Mossad — and the Syrian side brought the men who matter for any ceasefire, the heads of its general and military intelligence.¹ The stated aim was narrow and practical: agree the mechanisms to halt the Israeli strikes, arrests and targeted operations that have punctuated southern Syria, and stand up "a special operations room" in Jordan, run under US oversight, to keep any incident from spiralling — including one that drags in Turkey.¹

"Almost everything"

HOW MUCH OF A SYRIA-ISRAEL SECURITY DEAL THE TWO SIDES HAD REPORTEDLY AGREED ON PAPER BY EARLY 2026 — SECURITY ZONES IN THE SOUTH, A UN-ONLY BUFFER — BEFORE THE REGIONAL WAR FROZE THE TRACK

What makes this more than a photo of two spy chiefs is what it revives. By the start of the year the two governments had, on paper, agreed "almost everything" — arrangements for security zones in southern Syria and a buffer where only United Nations forces would sit — before the US-Israel-Iran war swept the table clean.² Sunday was an attempt to lift that draft off the floor and walk it toward a broader accord. The register is unmistakably post-Assad: a Damascus government talking security architecture with Israel, in Amman, brokered by Washington, is a sentence that could not have been written eighteen months ago.

THE DAMASCUS READ DAMASCUS • AL-SHAIBANI

Syria's framing, carried by its own state agency, is de-escalation and sovereignty: the strikes and incursions must stop, and a security agreement is the route to a "broader future accord" that keeps Israeli operations off Syrian soil. For a government still consolidating after the fall of the old regime, a quiet, deniable channel that halts the bombing is worth more than a public win — hence intelligence chiefs at the table rather than a signing ceremony.¹

THE ISRAELI READ JERUSALEM • VIA MOSSAD

Israel's account, reported through its own press, casts the meeting as damage control after a recent airstrike: a mechanism to prevent miscalculation on a volatile border, and to manage its own rivalry with Turkey so it does not detonate inside Syria. The security-zone-and-buffer logic serves Israel's core demand — a demilitarised near-border — without conceding the freedom of action it has exercised all year.³

THE SCEPTIC • THEY'VE SIGNED ON PAPER BEFORE

The caution writes across the whole file: these two agreed "almost everything" once already, and a war erased it in a week. A special-operations room deconflicts incidents; it does not resolve why Israel keeps striking, or what Damascus can actually deliver on its own territory while it is still stitching a state together. Turkey is the wild card no room in Amman controls. Read Sunday as a genuine opening — the first real track since the war — but price in that this border's paper agreements have a short shelf life. What would falsify the optimism: the next airstrike landing before the next meeting is scheduled.

Al Jazeera / Asharq Al-Awsat / Times of Israel, 23–24 Aug 2026 (characterised)

SOURCES 1. Al Jazeera / Asharq Al-Awsat / Xinhua / US News, 23–24 Aug 2026 — Syria-Israel US-mediated talks in Jordan, Sun 23 Aug; FM Asaad al-Shaibani (with heads of general & military intelligence) met Mossad director Roman Gofman; agenda = halting Israeli strikes/arrests/targeting, reviving a security-agreement track, a US-supervised "special operations room" in Jordan, and containing Israel-Türkiye tensions. 2. Al Jazeera / Asharq Al-Awsat, 24 Aug 2026 — the two sides had by early 2026 agreed "on paper to almost everything," incl. security zones in southern Syria and a UN-only buffer, before the regional war froze the track. 3. Times of Israel, 23 Aug 2026 — Mossad chief reported to meet Syrian FM to defuse tensions after an airstrike. Details reported via named outlets; single- or thinly-sourced framings flagged; verify against primaries.

THE WORLD · OTTAWA & WASHINGTON

The Tariff Stopped Being a Threat and Started Being a Forecast

Last issue logged the truce breaking; this week the economists put a number on it. Fifty per cent is now in force on roughly twenty-eight billion dollars of Canadian goods — and the debate has moved from whether Ottawa retaliates to how deep the recession runs.

The story advances from rhetoric to arithmetic. With Washington's fifty-per-cent tariffs live since Friday the twenty-first on roughly twenty-eight billion dollars of Canadian goods — most US outlets now cite that figure, above the twenty billion first reported — the weekend's news was not another threat but the first hard damage estimates.¹ BMO reckons the tariffs will shave about half a percentage point off Canadian growth; Capital Economics' Bradley Saunders said they "push Canada closer to a recession," particularly if Washington answers Ottawa's promised eighth-of-September retaliation with more of its own. The US trade representative, Jamieson Greer, disputed Canada's version, saying Ottawa "introduced new demands and backed away from commitments" even after Washington offered to cut tariffs on steel, autos and lumber.¹

~0.5pt

THE HIT TO CANADIAN GROWTH BMO NOW PENCILS IN FROM THE FIFTY-PER-CENT TARIFFS — WITH A RECESSION THE TAIL CASE IF THE TIT-FOR-TAT ESCALATES PAST 8 SEPTEMBER

THE CHATTER · PRICED AS A RUPTURE, NOT A FEINT

The mood among Canadian economists hardened over the weekend from "negotiating theatre" to "durable shock." The machinery and electronics lines are read as the hardest hit; the loonie and rate-cut bets moved with the forecasts. The contrarian note is that Ottawa's own retaliation is still two weeks out — a built-in window for an off-ramp — and that Canada has, before, quietly lifted CUSMA-compliant counter-tariffs once the cameras left.

BMO / Capital Economics / BNN Bloomberg, 22–24 Aug 2026 (characterised)

AROUND THE DESKS — IN BRIEF

Washington's "economic D-Day" lands softer than billed.

Treasury Secretary Bessent detailed "Operation Economic Outcast" — some sixty new designations of entities, individuals and vessels, with secondary-sanction categories widened to digital assets, gold, aviation and shipping, and a warning that China is "not exempt." Markets shrugged: Brent fell more than two per cent to below ninety-three dollars as the detail underwhelmed, the mirror image of the run-up.²

Ukraine trades warehouses for refineries. Russia struck a Mondelez plant in Sumy and fuel infrastructure at Odesa; Kyiv answered by hitting three Ozon logistics warehouses deep inside Russia, and Ozon's shares fell about twelve per cent. No summit, no ceasefire — attrition with a stock-market read-through.³

Trump floats a Kim meeting "at some point in 2026." The President said he intends to meet Kim Jong Un this year; Pyongyang was cool, with Kim Yo Jong saying she was "not aware of any recent communication." Signalled, not scheduled — the same holding pattern as last month.⁴

Setting the record straight. Last issue put the tariffed Canadian trade at about twenty billion dollars; the figure now most widely cited across US outlets is roughly twenty-eight billion. We flag the discrepancy and use the higher, better-sourced number here.¹

SOURCES 1. NBC News / BNN Bloomberg / Fortune / Fox Business, 22–24 Aug 2026 — US 50% tariffs live since 21 Aug on ~US\$28bn of Canadian goods (some earlier reports ~\$20bn — flagged); PM Carney "dollar for dollar" retaliation dated 8 Sep (steel, dairy, appliances, farm equipment, pulp, electronics); BMO ~0.5pt growth hit; Capital Economics (Bradley Saunders) "closer to a recession"; USTR Jamieson Greer said Canada "introduced new demands and backed away from commitments." Advances No. 81's "truce broke." 2. NBC / CNBC / Axios, 24 Aug 2026 — Bessent "Operation Economic Outcast": ~60 designations; categories widened to digital assets, gold, aviation, shipping; China "not exempt"; Brent fell >2% to below US\$93. Delta on No. 81's "economic D-Day." 3. Kyiv Independent / Astra, 23 Aug 2026 — Russia hit a Mondelez plant (Sumy) & Odesa fuel infrastructure; Ukraine struck three Ozon warehouses in Russia; Ozon --12%. Loss tallies Ukrainian-sourced — flagged. 4. NBC / CBS / Korea Herald — Trump intends a Kim meeting in 2026; NK cool ("not aware of any recent communication"). Signal, not schedule.

SINGAPORE • THE LITTLE RED DOT

The Highest Inflation in Nearly Two Years — and the Number That Undershot It

July's headline rate hit 2.2 per cent and core reached 2.0, the fastest since October 2024. Read past the headline: both prints came in below what economists expected, momentum fell month-on-month, and the jump was a switch flicked at the electricity meter, not a hot economy.

this story  

The number landed on Monday and it looks worse than it reads. Headline inflation rose to 2.2 per cent year-on-year in July, up from 1.9 in June; MAS core, which strips out accommodation and private transport, climbed to 2.0 per cent from 1.6 — its quickest pace since October 2024.¹ On the year-on-year line, "highest in nearly two years" is true. But the July print actually *undershot* the Bloomberg consensus of 2.4 per cent headline and 2.2 core, and the sequential momentum went the other way: prices fell 0.2 per cent month-on-month. The engine of the jump was singular and known — the regulated electricity tariff stepped up in July, pushing electricity-and-gas inflation to roughly nine per cent and housing-and-utilities to 1.3 from 0.3.¹

2.0%

MAS CORE INFLATION IN JULY — THE FASTEST SINCE OCT 2024, BUT BELOW THE 2.2% ECONOMISTS EXPECTED; THE FULL-YEAR FORECAST IS UNCHANGED AT 1.5–2.5%, AND Q2 GDP RAN HOT AT 5.7%

THE SCEPTIC • A COST-PUSH BLIP, NOT A RETURN OF INFLATION

The tempting read — inflation is back, MAS must tighten again — is the wrong one. The move is a one-off pass-through from a regulated tariff, not broad demand: core still came in under forecast, and prices fell month-on-month. MAS already tightened in April and left its full-year band untouched. A number driven by the power company changing its price list once tells you about the meter, not the economy; treat the two-year-high framing as arithmetically true and analytically misleading.

MAS/MTI release; economist commentary, 24 Aug 2026 (characterised)

The bigger domestic story this week was the money, not the meter. Sunday's National Day Rally converted its centrepiece into policy: the new SG Child Support Package folds the old Baby Bonus and Large Families schemes into a single stream worth up to about sixty-two thousand dollars per citizen child to age seventeen — the same regardless of birth order — reaching some 610,000 children across 380,000 households. It stacks a ten-thousand-dollar cash gift, thirty-two thousand in annual "child credits," and CDA grants and co-matching.² Alongside it, the flat income ceilings moved for the first time since 2019 — the BTO ceiling to sixteen thousand dollars and Executive Condominiums to eighteen, effective Monday — and working parents gained eight to twelve days of childcare leave a year.³

THE CHATTER • THE SIXTY-TWO-THOUSAND QUESTION

Local sentiment ran two tracks. On the family package, the perennial doubt resurfaced — whether any sum moves a total fertility rate at 0.87 — set against relief from parents who will simply take the money. On the Rally's build-up, the loudest thread was a fond grumble about a stripped-back National Day parade: a widely-upvoted "letdown" post mourning the missing F-16 flypast and Red Lions, answered by one airbase neighbour's much-quoted "THANK GOD, PLEASE MAKE IT PERMANENT."

r/singapore via The Online Citizen; AsiaOne comment threads, Aug 2026

ALSO ON THE ISLAND

The BTO calendar slips to make room. To let newly-eligible households re-qualify under the higher ceilings, the next Build-To-Order exercise moves from October to November — a small mechanical delta with real consequences for anyone timing an HFE letter.³

SOURCES 1. AsiaOne / CNBC / FX.co / Xinhua, 24 Aug 2026 — July CPI headline 2.2% y/y (from 1.9%), MAS core 2.0% (from 1.6%, fastest since Oct 2024); both undershot Bloomberg consensus (2.4% / 2.2%); -0.2% m/m; electricity-and-gas ~9% on the regulated July tariff step; housing-and-utilities 1.3% from 0.3%; full-year forecast unchanged 1.5–2.5%; Q2 GDP advance 5.7% y/y; MAS tightened Apr 2026. 2. AsiaOne / Mothership / population.gov.sg / madeforfamilies.gov.sg, 23 Aug 2026 — SG Child Support Package replaces Baby Bonus + Large Families, up to -S\$62k/citizen child to 17 (same regardless of birth order): S\$10k cash gift, S\$32k child credits (S\$2k/yr age 1–16), CDA First Step S\$5k + up to S\$5k co-matching; 610k children / 380k households; childcare leave 8/10/12 days for 1/2/3+ citizen children ≤12. 3. AsiaOne, 24 Aug 2026 — BTO income ceiling S\$14k–16k (eff. 24 Aug), EC S\$16k–18k, first change since 2019, ~8 in 10 households still eligible; next BTO exercise moved Oct–Nov 2026. 4. The Online Citizen, 10 Aug 2026 — r/singapore NDP 2026 reaction (no F-16 flypast / Red Lions); TFR 0.87.

THE ATELIER · BUY IT ONCE — NO. 9 · BED LINEN

Buy the Cloth, Not the Count — and Definitely Not the Logo

You spend a third of your life against these sheets, and almost everything the label shouts about is a lie. The quality is decided by a fibre you can't see and a weave you can feel — and in a Singapore bedroom, the thousand-dollar sateen is the wrong answer.

this story  

Start with the fibre, because most of a sheet's quality is settled before it is woven. The master variable is staple length: long fibres spin into smooth, strong, single-ply yarn that resists pilling; short ones leave cut ends to abrade and fuzz. The top tier is extra-long-staple cotton — Egyptian Giza or American Supima/Pima — and the tell is that a good brand *names the variety*: Giza 45, the "Queen," is about half of one per cent of Egypt's crop.¹ "Egyptian cotton" with no variety named is unverified; the label is unregulated, and the biggest fraud, Welspun's in 2016, saw Target pull some 750,000 mislabelled units.²

Then the weave. Percale is a plain one-over-one-under grid — matte, crisp, breathable, cool to the touch. Sateen floats four-or-more yarns over one for a silky lustre and a drape that traps heat. Linen, from European flax, is the most open weave of all and softens with every wash.³ For a Singapore bedroom, that is the whole decision: percale or linen win, sateen sleeps hot, Tencel lyocell is the humidity pick.

THE MAKERS, BY HONEST TIER

Entry of quality (US\$35–160). Genuine single-ply long-staple percale, no logo tax: Target's Threshold organic (~US\$35, preferred to pricier sets in testing), Quince's factory-direct percale and linen (~US\$100–150), and L.L.Bean's 280-count Pima percale — Wirecutter's number one over Brooklinen and Parachute.⁴

The sweet spot (US\$200–430). Where finishing and provenance earn their keep: Boll & Branch, Coyuchi's GOTS organic, Cultiver and Libeco linen, and England's Peter Reed, woven in its own Lancashire mill since 1861. Diminishing returns begin here.⁴

Who really weaves it. Sferra and Frette do weave in Italy (Como for Frette) — real, unlike much of the market off the

same Portuguese and Italian mills; but you can't verify a US\$4,000 Frette set's fibre justifies the multiple over a named-Giza rival.⁵

THE CHATTER · "BUY PERCALE AND STOP"

Its centre of gravity is unglamorous and correct: on r/BuyItForLife the advice is a single-ply long-staple percale set at S\$150–250, replaced in a decade — everything above is diminishing returns. The linen camp's line is that a set washed a few times only "gets better."

r/BuyItForLife / Wirecutter testers / interior-design roundups (characterised)

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE MONEY IS THEATRE

Four traps, by cost: thread-count inflation (600–1,200 is multi-ply counted); the "Egyptian cotton" con (no named Giza, assume ordinary); "bamboo" (almost always rayon, which the US FTC has fined the category some eight million dollars for mislabelling); and the grail markup (a large slice of a US\$4,000 Frette set is the name). The verdict for a hot, air-conditioned bedroom: a S\$150–250 percale or linen set beats a US\$600 sateen for almost everyone — and Heveya, Sojao and Heavenluxe build for the climate.⁵

r/BuyItForLife; SG stockist survey (reported), Aug 2026

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK NO. 10

Kitchen knives — Japanese bladesmiths as living ateliers; Sakai and Sanjo steel.

Towels — Imabari mills and the weighted-loop hierarchy; the bed's bathroom sibling.

Cashmere knitwear — ply and fibre grade versus "100% cashmere" theatre.

SOURCES 1. FlandB / Giza-cotton guides — staple length as the master variable; Giza 45 ~0.5% of Egypt's crop, Giza 87/88 the attainable ELs; Supima the US ELs mark; honest brands name the variety. 2. ASI Central / Fortune / Associations Now, 2016 — Welspun "Egyptian cotton" fraud; Target pulled ~750,000 Fieldcrest units, terminated Welspun; the label is essentially unregulated. 3. Naturepedic / Boll & Branch — percale (one-over-one, cool, matte) vs sateen (four-over-one, warmer, traps heat); linen the most open weave, softens with washing; percale/linen for hot sleepers, Tencel lyocell the humidity pick. 4. MATTEO / Boll & Branch (thread count) + Wirecutter — single-ply sweet spot ~200–400 (percale)/300–500 (sateen); multi-ply inflation turns ~300 into "1,200"; L.L.Bean 280 Pima percale rated #1 over Brooklinen/Parachute; Target Threshold ~US\$35 preferred to pricier sets; Quince ~US\$100–150; sweet spot Boll & Branch / Coyuchi / Cultiver / Libeco / Peter Reed (Lancashire mill since 1861). 5. Sferra / Frette / Forbes Vetted (woven in Italy/Como; Giza 45; Frette US\$500–5,000+); OEcotextiles / FTC (~US\$8.06m penalties; "rayon made from bamboo"); Heveya / Sojao / Heavenluxe (SG climate stockists; Tencel/linen). Community sentiment attributed to named forums/testers, reported from search-surfaced threads, not transcribed.

TECHNOLOGY · SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY

A Chinese Lab Built a Model Too Good at Finding Holes — So It Kept the Keys

Z.ai shipped GLM-5.3 this month, then held the open weights for two weeks to harden them, after the model scored top of its class at discovering software vulnerabilities and reportedly turned up a serious one in a popular coding tool. An open-weights lab voluntarily withholding weights is the sovereignty story of the week.

this story  

The interesting release this month is the one you can't download yet. Z.ai launched GLM-5.3 on the fourteenth of August on the same 743-billion-parameter base as GLM-5.2, with every gain coming from scaled post-training rather than a bigger model. What stopped the presses was a benchmark: it posted 84.5 per cent on CyberGym, a test of finding real software vulnerabilities — ahead of Z.ai's cited figures for the leading American and rival Chinese models — and reportedly surfaced a "potentially serious vulnerability" in the coding tool Cursor.² So the lab did something an open-weights house rarely does: it gated the most sensitive cyber functions to verified users and held the open weights roughly two weeks for safety hardening, with publication due around the twenty-eighth. A Chinese lab choosing not to ship weights, on offence-risk grounds, is a new note in the sovereignty score.

84.5%

GLM-5.3'S SELF-REPORTED SCORE ON CYBERGYM (FINDING REAL SOFTWARE VULNERABILITIES) — AHEAD OF Z.AI'S CITED FIGURES FOR GPT-5.6 AND ITS CHINESE RIVAL; INDEPENDENT REPLICATION IS STILL PENDING, SO READ IT AS A CLAIM, NOT A RESULT

The week's other clock is Nvidia's. The company reports on Wednesday, having guided to about ninety-one billion dollars of revenue at a gross margin near seventy-five per cent, with the Street sitting a notch higher and its China sales left entirely outside the guide.¹ The two stories rhyme: one is about who is allowed the compute, the other about whether the compute still pays. On the first, the export-control fight has quietly changed venue. The

"rent-a-Blackwell" loophole — you can't ship the chip, but you can rent the login — still stands, with the House-passed Remote Access Security Act stalled in the Senate; meanwhile Beijing has become the binding constraint on its own side, licensing its champions only a fraction of the H200s they are cleared to buy.³

CHINA'S H200: CLEARED vs DELIVERED

Licensed to buy (each, ByteDance / Tencent)

75,000

Actually delivered so far

~10,000 · 13%

NDRC runs a per-purchase approval mirroring Commerce's — Beijing throttling its own imp

A Meridian figure. Source: Tom's Hardware, Aug 2026.

THE SCEPTIC · THE CIRCLE THAT FUNDS ITSELF

The bear case on the whole complex is that the money moves in a loop. More than seven hundred and fifty billion dollars of announced deals now knit the same names together — a giant chip order here, a data-centre backstop there — while the Magnificent Seven's combined free cash flow has fallen to about eight per cent of quarterly sales, its lowest since early 2024, and Alphabet turned free-cash-flow-negative in the second quarter for the first time as its debt roughly doubled. Michael Burry's diagram of the arrangement made the rounds; the tell is revenue that "shows up strong even as free cash flow turns negative." A weak Nvidia guide on Wednesday would test whether the circle spins without a new dollar entering it.

Bloomberg / 24-7 Wall St; Michael Burry (characterised), Aug 2026

SOURCES 1. IG / TradingKey, Aug 2026 — Nvidia guided Q2 FY2027 revenue ~US\$91bn (±2%), GAAP gross margin ~74.9%; reports 26 Aug; Vera Rubin in production, shipments expected Q3; China sales outside guidance. 2. VentureBeat / Axios / Reuters, 14 Aug 2026 — GLM-5.3 (743B base, all gains from post-training), 84.5% CyberGym (Z.ai self-reported, ahead of its cited GPT-5.6 83.6% / Mythos 5 83.8%), reportedly found a "serious vulnerability" in Cursor; sensitive cyber functions gated to verified users; open weights held ~2 weeks (~28 Aug). Benchmark self-reported, unreplicated — flagged. 3. Tom's Hardware, Aug 2026 — Remote Access Security Act passed House 369–22 (12 Jan 2026), Senate S.3519 pending; loophole exemplars (INF Tech 2,300 Blackwell via Indonesia; Tencent ~US\$1.2bn/15,000 via Japan's Datasection); ByteDance/Tencent received ~10,000 H200s each = 13% of the 75,000 each is licensed to buy; NDRC per-purchase approval mirrors Commerce. 4. Bloomberg / 24-7 Wall St, Jul–Aug 2026 — >US\$750bn of announced AI deals; Mag-7 combined FCF ~7.9% of quarterly sales (lowest since early 2024); Alphabet FCF-negative in Q2 (long-term debt ~doubled to ~\$98bn); Michael Burry circular-financing warning. Figures attributed; verify against primaries.

TECHNOLOGY • THE HOME LAB

The Frontier Model Everyone's Talking About Won't Fit — This One Will

GLM-5.3 is the headline, but at 743 billion parameters it never touches a home rig. The delta that actually matters for a single 5090 shipped the same day: a dense 27-billion model that lands in seventeen gigabytes and leaves half the card free.

The honest home-lab story this fortnight is not the model making the headlines. Alibaba open-weighted Qwen3.8-27B on the fourteenth of August — a dense, Apache-licensed, natively vision-capable model with a quarter-million-token context that quantises to about seventeen gigabytes at Q4. That fits a single RTX 5090's thirty-two gigabytes with roughly half the card free for context and key-value cache, no second GPU required, and it scores around 52 on one widely-watched intelligence index against 38 for the same-architecture Qwen3.6 it replaces.¹ For the reader running one 5090 or a pair, this is the new default local model, and it did not need a data centre to run.

~17 GB

QWEN3.8-27B AT Q4 ON A 32 GB RTX 5090 — LEAVING HEADROOM FOR 32K-PLUS CONTEXT; A DUAL-5090 BOX (64 GB) INSTEAD UNLOCKS A FULL-QUALITY 70B AT Q4, AROUND 27 TOKENS/SEC ON A TENSOR SPLIT

Set the frontier headline against the hardware and the gap is the whole point. GLM-5.3's weights, due around the twenty-eighth, are a 743-billion-parameter object; even the most aggressive one-bit quantisation of that line needs on the order of 223 gigabytes, which means a four-card A100 box, not a tower under a desk.² The practical verdict is blunt: the exciting open-weights drop is, for a single 5090 or a dual-5090, a non-event — admire it, don't try to run it, and run Qwen3.8-27B instead. Tooling moved only modestly: Ollama's August desktop update brought faster model loading and prefill-restore fixes, while vLLM with FP8 stays the throughput path and llama.cpp the flexibility one.³

THE CHATTER • FRONTIER HEADLINES VS THE 32-GIG REALITY

The loudest developer thread on the GLM launch cleared a thousand points, and the home-lab-relevant takeaway there and across the model-tracker write-ups is exactly the reader's own thesis: the distance between "frontier open weights" and "what actually fits thirty-two or sixty-four gigabytes." The community's quiet consensus is that the useful frontier for a single high-end card is now a well-tuned 27-to-32-billion dense model, not whatever 700-billion object leads the week's benchmarks.

Hacker News; r/LocalLLaMA / model-tracker write-ups (characterised)

THE SCEPTIC • TRUST THE CARD, NOT THE TOKEN-COUNTER

Two cautions. The throughput and VRAM numbers quoted for the 50-series come mostly from model-tracker and vendor-adjacent blogs, not primary benchmarks, so treat the tokens-per-second as indicative and measure on your own rig before believing them. And the intelligence-index leap from 38 to 52 is a single aggregator's score on a young model — impressive, unreplicated, and worth confirming against your actual workload rather than a leaderboard. The 5090 story is real; the decimal points around it are not yet.

modelfit / compute-market figures (characterised), Aug 2026

WHAT FITS WHAT

Single 5090 (32 GB). The sweet spot is a 27-to-32-billion dense model at Q4-Q6 — Qwen3.8-27B at ~17 GB leaves room for long context; a 70B squeezes in only at a lossy Q3.²

Dual 5090 (64 GB). The upgrade that earns its cost: a full-quality 70B at Q4_K_M with long context, reported around twenty-seven tokens a second on a tensor split.²

GLM-5.3 (743 B). Out of reach — even a one-bit quant needs about 223 GB, a four-card A100 box. Admire the benchmark; run Qwen locally.²

SOURCES 1. explainx.ai / Yotta Labs, 14 Aug 2026 — Qwen3.8-27B: dense, Apache-2.0, native vision-language, 262,144-token context, ~17 GB at Q4_K_M, fits a single 32 GB RTX 5090; ~52 on Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index vs ~38 for Qwen3.6-27B; Qwen 3.7 never shipped. 2. modelfit.io / compute-market — RTX 5090 (32 GB) runs ~27-35B dense at Q4-Q6, 70B at Q3; dual-5090 (64 GB) full-quality 70B Q4_K_M, ~27 tok/s via Ollama tensor split (aggregator figures — indicative). Thunder Compute / kingy.ai — GLM-5.3 743B base; even 1-bit ~223 GB, 4×A100-80GB practical entry; will not run on a 5090 or dual-5090. 3. Releasebot — Ollama August 2026 desktop update (faster loading, caching/prefill-restore fixes); vLLM+FP8 the throughput path, llama.cpp/GGUF the flexibility path.

THE KIT • GEAR WE'RE WATCHING

A Three-Hundred-Dollar Cinema on Your Face — the Morning a Thousand-Dollar Watch Is One Livestream Away

VITURE's Pro 2 glasses ship with real reviews and a price cut that undercuts the entry field; Garmin's "Play Harder" event, today, is expected to drop the Fēnix 9 and Enduro 4. One you can buy; the other you can only watch.

this story  

The one you can put on today is VITURE's Pro 2, the fifth-anniversary version of its wearable display, out on the sixth of August at two hundred and ninety-nine US dollars — a real cut from the first Pro's four-fifty. It pairs a Sony Micro-OLED panel per eye at nineteen-twenty by ten-eighty and up to a hundred and twenty hertz, a fifty-degree field of view at sixteen hundred nits, and at sixty-three grams it's a fifth lighter than before, with built-in myopia dials from zero to minus five so the near-sighted skip inserts, and — pointedly — no cameras.¹ Reviewers landed on the same verdict: a dark horse in the entry-level race, sharp for the money.³ It is not a buy-once flagship; it's the cheap thrill that shames pricier rivals, a virtual one-hundred-and-forty-six-inch screen for a plane seat.

US\$299

THE VITURE PRO 2, DOWN FROM THE FIRST PRO'S US\$459 — SONY MICRO-OLED, 120 HZ, 1,600 NITS, 63 G, DIOPTRE DIALS BUILT IN, NO CAMERAS

The one you can only watch is the flagship. Garmin has set a "Play Harder" livestream for today, the twenty-fifth, widely expected to unveil the Fēnix 9, a Fēnix E and the Enduro 4 — the buy-once, hand-it-down adventure watches this reader actually keeps. A European retailer's listing has already catalogued eighteen Fēnix 9 variants, and the rumour mill pegs pricing from around a thousand dollars.² Treat all of that as leak, not gospel: Garmin has published no

specs or prices, and the model list and the figure are pattern-inference until the stream goes live.⁴ What is confirmed is the timing — the day's genuine gear event breaks after this page is set.

THE CHATTER • THE INTERNET ALREADY KNOWS THE WATCH

The enthusiast press has spent a week reverse-engineering the Fēnix 9 from that eighteen-variant retailer leak, down to Pro and inReach editions — good "we already know" colour, and explicitly leak-sourced. On the glasses, the reviewer consensus is unusually tidy: the Pro 2 is the value pick of the category, with the sharpness-for-price the recurring praise. Each individual spec traces to VITURE's own numbers, but multiple independent hands-on reviews corroborate them.

the5krunner / garminrumors; Tom's Guide / Gizmodo (characterised)

THE SCEPTIC • CHEAP THRILL, LEAKED FLAGSHIP

Two honest cautions. The Pro 2 is entry-tier by design — no cameras, tethered, a screen for a bag rather than a lifetime object — so pitch it as the affordable foil to a real buy-once purchase, not the purchase itself. And nothing about the Fēnix 9 is real until Garmin says so this afternoon: a retailer's SKU dump and a "from ~US\$999" are the internet guessing well, not a spec sheet. Watch the stream before you form a view, and certainly before you pre-order.

Reviewer consensus; garminrumors leak caveats, Aug 2026

SOURCES 1. Tom's Guide, Aug 2026 — VITURE Pro 2 XR glasses, released 6 Aug, US\$299 (down from the first Pro's US\$459); Sony Micro-OLED 1920×1080/eye, up to 120 Hz, 50° FOV, 1,600 nits, 63 g, built-in 0 to -5.0D myopia dials, no cameras, ~146-inch virtual screen. 2. the5krunner / garminrumors, 22–25 Aug 2026 — Garmin "Play Harder" YouTube livestream 25 Aug (12:00 UK), expected Fēnix 9 / Fēnix E / Enduro 4. 3. Gizmodo / Creative Bloq — Pro 2 hands-on reviews, "dark horse in the entry-level AR race," sharpness-for-price; individual specs trace to VITURE's numbers, corroborated across independent reviews. 4. gadgetsandwearables / garminrumors — 18 Fēnix 9 SKUs listed by a Czech retailer, rumoured from ~US\$999; SPECS & PRICE ARE LEAK/PATTERN-INFERENCE, unconfirmed until the event (Garmin has published nothing). Context: DJI Osmo 360 II (13 Aug, 8K60) deliberately not covered — too close to No. 80's 360-camera lead.

THE GOOD LIFE · OBJECTS & ESCAPES

A Solar Formula One Watch for a Farewell Lap — and What You're Really Paying For

TAG Heuer marked Zandvoort's last Dutch Grand Prix with two limited Formula 1 Solargraphs: 38 millimetres, light-charged, a genuinely useful movement in a genuinely disposable price bracket. The horology is entry-level; the premium is the story.

this story  

TAG Heuer unveiled the pair trackside in early August and dated them to a genuine ending: the weekend of the twenty-first to twenty-third was Zandvoort's final Dutch Grand Prix under its current contract.³ Both are 38-millimetre, fully sandblasted steel, with a grey opalin dial and orange-and-red accents, run by the solar Solargraph calibre TH50-00 — roughly a minute of direct sun buys a day of running, and a full charge holds up to ten months in the dark.¹ The orange-rubber-strap reference is a fifteen-hundred-piece run at about two thousand one hundred and fifty US dollars; the steel bracelet is a thousand pieces at two-two-fifty. It is a welcome return to a wearable case size and a solar movement that never needs a battery — the buy-once virtues, in an entry-price Swiss sports watch.

10 months

HOW LONG A FULL LIGHT-CHARGE RUNS THE TAG FORMULA 1 SOLARGRAPH IN TOTAL DARKNESS — A MINUTE OF DIRECT SUN TOPS UP A DAY; THE TWO ZANDVOORT EDITIONS RUN 1,500 AND 1,000 PIECES AT ~US\$2,150 / US\$2,250

For the audiophile end of the desk, the object of the year is stranger: Cayin's CP6, a portable CD player with two miniature vacuum tubes glowing behind the disc tray, a Class-A output stage and a hi-res DAC, at six hundred and ninety-nine dollars.² It launched in May, so it isn't this week's news — but it is the piece the hi-fi forums keep circling, the physical-media revival's most improbable flagship. Cross-reference the turntable this desk covered earlier in the month: the analogue-ritual trade is alive, and it now spins compact discs through valves.

THE CHATTER · SOLAR, SMALL, AND SENSIBLY PRICED

On WatchUSeek and the watch subreddits, the warm notes are the same two: solar power in an affordable Swiss sports watch is a genuinely useful proposition, and the return to a 38-millimetre case is overdue after years of dinner-plate diameters. The recurring debate is the one every limited edition provokes — whether the tie-in premium is worth it over the standard Solargraph. On the audio side, the forums treat the Cayin as a delightful curio, not a giant-killer.

WatchUSeek / r/watches; Darko.Audio / Head-Fi (characterised)

THE SCEPTIC · YOU'RE BUYING ZANDVOORT, NOT HOROLOGY

Be clear-eyed about the money. Around two thousand two hundred dollars buys a solar-quartz entry-level Formula 1 with a limited-edition markup — the standard F1 Solargraph is closer to eighteen hundred⁴ — so the premium is the orange grandstand and the "final race" story, not the watchmaking. And "final" is doing soft work: it is a contract lapsing at Zandvoort, not a permanent farewell, so the scarcity framing is thinner than it sounds. Lovely watch, honest movement; just don't mistake the collectible narrative for value.

Enthusiast-press pricing (Fratello / Oracle of Time), Aug 2026

ALSO ON THE BENCH

IFA looms for the headphone crowd. Ahead of Berlin's IFA in early September, the flagship-audio chatter is on Meze Audio's ARTA — a six-thousand-dollar open-back planar — and a new Sennheiser Momentum wireless flagship. Dates are still soft; treat them as the season's watch-list, not this week's news.²

The physical-media thread. The Cayin's CD revival rhymes with the turntable this desk covered earlier in the month — the analogue-ritual trade is having a genuine, improbable moment (see also The Kit, [p9](#)).

SOURCES 1. Fratello / Oracle of Time / Haute Time, Aug 2026 — TAG Heuer Formula 1 Solargraph 38mm, two Zandvoort limited editions unveiled ~10 Aug; sandblasted steel, grey opalin dial, solar calibre TH50-00 (~1 min direct sun = 1 day; full charge up to 10 months in the dark), 100m WR. 2. Gear Patrol / ecoustics / Darko.Audio — Cayin CP6 tube portable CD player, US\$699/€998, dual Raytheon JAN-6418 tubes, Class A, hi-res DAC/Bluetooth/CD-ripping, ~7.5h battery; launched 21 May 2026 (framed as the year's hi-fi obsession, not a new drop). IFA 2026 (Berlin, early Sep) flagship-audio chatter — Meze Audio ARTA (~US\$6,000 open-back planar, Rinaro MZ5 driver), new Sennheiser Momentum wireless flagship; announcement dates soft — flagged. 3. Team-BHP / RacingNews365 — 2026 Dutch GP weekend 21–23 Aug (race 23 Aug), Zandvoort's final race under its current contract. 4. Fratello / Oracle of Time — pricing: orange rubber strap 1,500 pieces ~US\$2,150, steel bracelet 1,000 pieces ~US\$2,250; standard F1 Solargraph ~US\$1,800 (the limited-edition markup is the Zandvoort story, not horology).

SCREEN & SOUND · CULTURE DESK

Venice Opens on a Young Press Baron; a Tennis Elegy Lands Before the Open

The Lido raises its curtain on Danny Boyle's Murdoch origin story and a competition thick with debuts; on streaming, a Djokovic documentary times itself to the US Open — and keeps the warts discreetly off-camera.

this story  

The film-festival autumn opens in Venice, running the second to the twelfth of September, with Danny Boyle's *Ink* — Rupert Murdoch's 1969 acquisition of *The Sun*, with Guy Pearce as the young mogul — as the curtain-raiser. The competition leans on debuts and pedigree: Casey Affleck's directorial first, *Company*; Andrea Pallaoro's *The Echo Chamber*, built from a final Bernardo Bertolucci screenplay and starring Alicia Vikander; and Nanni Moretti in the mix.¹ No scores exist yet — these are premieres, not verdicts — so read the week as buzz, not consensus, with Telluride's secret lineup landing days later.

8.1

THE EARLY IMDB USER SCORE FOR *NOVAK DJOKOVIC: THE WOLF IN WINTER* (PRIME VIDEO, ~20 AUG) — BUT ROTTEN TOMATOES AND METACRITIC CARRIED NO AGGREGATED CRITIC SCORE AT PRESS TIME; DON'T PRINT A PERCENTAGE THAT DOESN'T EXIST YET

On streaming, the pick with a real peg is *Novak Djokovic: The Wolf in Winter*, which arrived on Prime Video around the twentieth, directed by Jason Hehir of *The Last Dance*, with Nadal, Agassi, Sampras and Becker on camera — timed precisely to the US Open's start on the thirtieth.² The music week belonged to K-pop and an estate: NCT 127's seventh album *BLINGY* dropped on the twenty-fourth, ENHYPEN's *THE SIN : BLISS* on the twenty-first, and a Prince estate collection of unreleased recordings, *Timeless*, before month's end.³

THE CHATTER · A FESTIVAL SELLS ANTICIPATION

The honest read on the week is that Venice manufactures red-carpet anticipation, not critical verdicts — the competition titles have not screened for press, so any "consensus" is premature. The Djokovic documentary carries genuine nostalgia for the reader who lived through the Federer–Nadal–Djokovic era, and the guest list is the draw; the tennis press flagged the US Open timing as the obvious commercial play.

Deadline / IndieWire; tennis press (characterised)

THE SCEPTIC · THE AUTHORISED-ACCESS PROBLEM

The Federal panned the Djokovic film as "hardly the tribute he deserves"⁴ — the classic hazard of the authorised documentary, where access is traded for polish and the difficult chapters go soft. Pair that with the festival caution and the desk's standing rule holds: an eight-point-one from early users and a wall of premiere buzz are not a settled judgement. Wait for the press screenings and the actual reviews before believing either the hype or the hagiography.

The Federal review; festival-coverage norms, Aug 2026

ALSO SCREENING & PLAYING

The rest of Venice's competition. Beyond the openers, the Lido runs deep: Nanni Moretti's *It Will Happen Tonight* with Louis Garrel, and May el-Toukhy's *Woman Unknown* — the sole female-directed film in competition — with Giovanni Veronesi's *Dio Ride* closing the festival.¹

Telluride keeps its secret. The Colorado festival (4–7 Sep, Rebecca Hall guest director) holds its lineup until the eve of opening — the autumn's other awards-season tell, landing just as Venice's verdicts firm up.¹

One more on the playlist. Earlier in the month, Ayra Starr's third album *Starr Girl* (Mavin, 14 Aug) is the Afrobeats release worth a listen alongside the K-pop and estate drops.³

SOURCES 1. Deadline / The Hollywood Reporter / IndieWire, Aug 2026 — Venice 2026 (2–12 Sep): opener Danny Boyle's *Ink* (Guy Pearce as Rupert Murdoch, 1969 acquisition of *The Sun*); competition incl. Casey Affleck's debut *Company*, Andrea Pallaoro's *The Echo Chamber* (final Bertolucci screenplay, Alicia Vikander), Nanni Moretti's *It Will Happen Tonight* (Louis Garrel), May el-Toukhy's *Woman Unknown* (sole female-directed competition film), closing film Giovanni Veronesi's *Dio Ride*; Telluride 4–7 Sep (Rebecca Hall guest director, lineup secret till opening). 2. Tennis Now / Yahoo Sports — *Novak Djokovic: The Wolf in Winter*, Prime Video ~20 Aug, dir. Jason Hehir (*The Last Dance*), features Nadal/Agassi/Sampras/Becker; IMDb 8.1; RT/Metacritic carried no aggregated critic score at press time (flagged — do not print a %); timed to the US Open (from 30 Aug). 3. Billboard / JamBase — NCT 127 *BLINGY* (24 Aug), ENHYPEN *THE SIN : BLISS* (21 Aug), Prince estate *Timeless* (before end Aug), Ayra Starr *Starr Girl* (Mavin, 14 Aug). 4. The Federal — dissenting review of the Djokovic documentary ("hardly the tribute he deserves").

THE FAMILY DESK · RAISING THEM WELL

The Study That Ends at Exactly Twelve — and the Finding That Reframes the Panic

A new paper of more than ten thousand children measures phone ownership against depression, sleep and weight at precisely the age of a Secondary One student. The more useful result, from a separate study, is that it isn't the hour-count that tracks the harm — it's the addictive pattern.

this story  

The freshest evidence lands exactly on this desk's child. A January paper in the American Academy of Pediatrics' journal, drawing on 10,588 children in the long-running ABCD study, tested smartphone ownership and — crucially — the age a child first got one against depression, obesity and insufficient sleep, with the outcomes measured at age twelve.¹ A twelve-year-old entering secondary school sits in what the researchers call early adolescence, the ten-to-fourteen band, and the value of the study is that it studies her cohort rather than a number frozen a decade ago. The headline temptation is to read it as one more reason to panic about screens; the more careful reading is where the real guidance lives.

10,588

CHILDREN IN THE ABCD COHORT BEHIND THE NEW PEDIATRICS PAPER ON SMARTPHONE OWNERSHIP, AGE OF ACQUISITION, AND HEALTH AT TWELVE — THE AGE OF A SECONDARY ONE STUDENT, NOT A NUMBER FROZEN A DECADE AGO

Because the sharper 2026 finding is a switch in what to measure. A study in the JAMA network found that it is the high or rising *addictive* use of phones, social media and games — not raw screen minutes — that tracks with worse mental health and suicidal behaviour in early adolescents.² That reframes the whole parent conversation: away from a stopwatch and toward the relationship with the device. The signals that matter are compulsion, conflict when the phone is removed, secrecy and displaced sleep — not whether today totalled three hours or four.

THE CHATTER · THE WORD LOCAL PARENTS KEEP USING IS "ADDICTION"

On r/singaporeparents and the local parenting threads, the anxiety this cycle is less about screen hours and more about device dependence — parents describing compulsive, OCD-like checking and distress on removal, layered over the ordinary nerves of the Secondary One jump. It maps neatly onto the research shift: the community's felt problem is the addictive pattern, which is exactly the thing the new studies say to watch.

r/singaporeparents; AsiaOne / HoneyKids threads (characterised)

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T IMPORT THE PANIC WHOLESALE

The corrective is built into the science. Researchers such as Candice Odgers and Andrew Przybylski have argued for years that the causal case for "social media caused the teen mental-health crisis" is largely correlational, and the blanket-hours alarmism popularised by *The Anxious Generation* is contested. The addictive-pattern finding is itself the more disciplined frame: it says watch function, sleep and compulsion, not a minute-counter. General guidance for a parent, not medical advice.

Odgers / Przybylski (British Journal of Developmental Psychology tradition), characterised

WHAT ACTUALLY PREDICTS HARM

The pattern, not the clock. The 2026 studies point at compulsion, conflict when the device is removed, secrecy and displaced sleep — the markers of addictive use — rather than a daily minute total. A child who reads for four hours is not the child the research is worried about.²

The age of the first phone matters. The new paper's whole design turns on *when* a child got the device, not just whether she has one — an argument for scaffolding a first smartphone rather than handing it over early and hoping.¹

SOURCES 1. Pediatrics (AAP journal), Jan 2026 — "Smartphone Ownership, Age of Smartphone Acquisition, and Health Outcomes in Early Adolescence," N=10,588 ABCD participants; ownership & age-of-acquisition vs depression, obesity, insufficient sleep at age 12. Early adolescence = WHO 10–14 band. 2. JAMA network / NewYork-Presbyterian (PubMed 40531519) — high/rising addictive-use trajectories of social media, phones and video games (not raw screen time) track with suicidal behaviour and worse mental health in early adolescents. 3. Candice Odgers / Andrew Przybylski — the causal evidence for social-media-driven teen mental-health decline is largely correlational; the "screen-hours" alarmism (cf. *The Anxious Generation*) is contested. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE TWEEN YEARS

The School Locked the Phone Away. The Workaround Is the Real Story.

Singapore's tightened secondary-school phone rules are now in force — and the honest follow-up isn't the ban, it's the enforcement gap, and what a parent should actually do with the hours the school can't police.

The delta since last month is not the rule but its edges. From the start of 2026 the Ministry of Education tightened secondary-school phone use — no phones at recess or co-curricular activities, devices stored in lockers or bags — and the fresh reporting is on the gap between policy and practice.¹ Researchers at the National Institute of Education have found what every parent suspects: students "can still outsmart the rules," and one commentary noted the tightened regime amounts to "just one and a half hours without phones" across a school day. The ban does useful work; it does not do the parenting.

10–14

THE EARLY-ADOLESCENCE BAND A SECONDARY ONE STUDENT SITS IN — THE AGE THE NEW RESEARCH IS STRATIFIED FOR; GUIDANCE PITCHED AT A TEN-YEAR-OLD IS THE WRONG GUIDANCE FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD ENTERING SECONDARY SCHOOL

So the practical programme is small and evidence-led. Protect sleep first — no phone in the bedroom overnight, since night-time device use is the cleanest link to shorter, more broken sleep, and sleep drives the puberty-age changes far more than the calendar does. Scaffold rather than surrender the first smartphone: staged access, shared rules, and a parent who stays in the loop through the Secondary One transition rather than handing over a glass rectangle and hoping. Independence, yes — but with guidance attached.²

The sleep piece deserves its own emphasis, because at twelve it is biology, not stubbornness. The adolescent body clock shifts later at puberty, so a Secondary One student is already fighting to fall asleep early — and a phone in the room, with its notifications and its light, pushes the window later still and shortens the total. The cleanest single

intervention a parent can make is also the least popular: the phone charges outside the bedroom overnight. The app limits and content filters are second-order next to protecting the hours the growing brain actually runs its maintenance on.²

The transition itself is the other thing worth naming. A new school, a longer commute, a wider social world and a first personal device usually arrive in the same six months, and it is the pile-up, not any single item, that stresses a twelve-year-old. The research points where common sense does: keep one anchor steady — a shared meal, a bedtime routine, an unhurried conversation — while the rest of her world reorganises. The phone is far easier to manage as one change among many than as the battleground for all of them.

FOR A SECONDARY ONE PARENT · THE SHORT LIST

Four things that survive the research: keep the phone out of the bedroom at night; watch for the addictive tells (compulsion, secrecy, distress on removal) rather than the clock; treat the school's ninety minutes as a floor, not a solution; and protect the sleep window, because at twelve it's biology, not defiance. Everything else is negotiable.

THE SCEPTIC · A BAN IS NOT A PLAN

The tidy comfort — the school confiscated the problem — is the thing to resist. Ninety phone-free minutes against a device that lives in a pocket the rest of the day is a nudge, not a fix, and treating it as a solution outsources a job that is a parent's. The honest read on the Singapore ban is that it buys attention in class and changes little at home; the home hours are where the addictive-pattern risk actually sits. General guidance, not medical advice.

NIE/NTU reporting; HoneyKids commentary (characterised)

SOURCES 1. AsiaOne / NIE-NTU / HoneyKids Asia, 2026 — MOE tightened secondary-school phone rules from Jan 2026 (no use at recess/CCA, locker/bag storage); NIE reporting that students "can still outsmart the rules"; HoneyKids "just 1.5 hours without phones." Delta on No. 81's coverage of the ban itself. 2. Journal of Adolescent Health (bedtime-screen / sleep cohort) — night-time phone use linked to shorter, more disturbed sleep; sleep tracks puberty-stage change more than chronological age. Practical guidance labelled general information, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK · THE BIG PICTURE

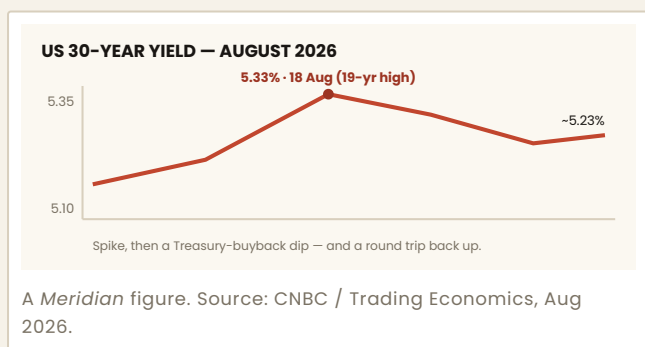
Gold Clears a Record, the Long Bond Gets Rescued Again, and Friday Belongs to a New Chair

Bullion took out a fresh high as the thirty-year yield — a nineteen-year peak days earlier — eased only because the Treasury signalled it would fund more of its own buying. The dollar is soft into Kevin Warsh's first Jackson Hole, where the market prices a hold and, at the tail, a hike — not a cut.

this story  

VWRA 193.30	US 30Y ~5.23%	DXY ~98.7	USD/JPY 158.9	GOLD ~\$4,640	BITCOIN ~\$78k
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Gold did the talking. Bullion cleared a fresh record this week, opening above four thousand six hundred dollars for the first time since mid-May, while bitcoin ran the high-octane version of the same trade, up about twenty-three per cent over seven days toward seventy-eight thousand.¹ The engine was the bond market. The thirty-year Treasury yield had touched five-point-three-three per cent on the eighteenth — a nineteen-year high — as a forty-trillion-dollar debt pile, a July deficit of four hundred and thirty-two billion, and a wall of AI-related corporate supply crowded the government out of its own borrowing.²



So the issuer rescued its own market. The Treasury had already doubled its long-dated buybacks toward four billion dollars an operation, and this week signalled it could tap its roughly one-trillion-dollar cash account to fund more — nudging the thirty-year back to about five-point-two-three.² Follow the plumbing: a buyback is a liquidity injection, it

softened the dollar, and the debasement bid lit gold and bitcoin. Name the regime and the moves stop looking like separate stories — fiscal dominance: a hawkish Fed that held even as July payrolls fell, three dissents wanting a hike and no September cut priced, and an issuer easing by the back door instead.³

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

One force, four reads. Global equities stay buoyant on the soft dollar and the backstop, but hostage to the long end and most exposed if Friday reprices higher. Global aggregate bonds are the fragile leg, between the buyback bid and the fiscal term premium. Gold fires on all three cylinders — weaker dollar, capped real yields, haven demand — and bitcoin is its leveraged version. It hangs on Warsh's keynote. *Market explanation, not advice; forecasts are forecasts.*

Meridian Macro read, 25 Aug 2026

THE SCEPTIC · THE VIGILANTE STORY IS ONLY HALF-BUILT

Two cautions. Recent Treasury auctions showed no abrupt fall in demand⁴ — so the long-end selloff may be as much term-premium and plumbing as a buyers' strike, and the "bond vigilante" narrative runs ahead of the tape. And with about seven in ten managers expecting a neutral Warsh, the risk is a non-event that leaves the fiscal problem where it was. No level here is invented; unverifiable prints are held.

CNBC / Goldman Sachs FX desk; BofA fund-manager survey (characterised)

SOURCES 1. Fortune / CNBC / CoinStats, 24 Aug 2026 — gold ~US\$4,640 spot (opened >\$4,600 first time since 15 May, peaked >\$4,700; Dec future opened \$4,673.40); bitcoin ~US\$77.7–79.1k (+~23.5% 7d). Levels ~Mon 24 Aug close, held pending clean prints: VWRA US\$193.30 (52wk 156.50–196.50, YTD +13.8%); DXY ~98.7 (touched 98.55, lowest since mid-May); USD/SGD ~1.2781; USD/JPY ~158.9; Brent below US\$93; STI ~5,691 (record 5,774.21 on 11 Aug). Global-agg proxies AGGU (~5.83, last clean 4 Aug) and BNDW (~\$68) awaiting a 24 Aug print. 2. CNBC / 24-7 Wall St / Bloomberg, 18–24 Aug 2026 — 30Y Treasury 5.33% intraday (19-yr high, 18 Aug), eased to ~5.234% (24 Aug) after reports the Treasury could tap its ~\$1tn General Account to fund more of its doubled (~\$4bn/operation) long-dated buybacks; US debt topped \$40tn; July deficit \$432bn (widest since Mar 2021). 3. CNBC / MNI / BofA — July payrolls ~23k; Fed held 3.50–3.75% (29 Jul) with 3 dissents favouring a HIKE; Sep priced ~64–69% hold / ~30% hike (no cut); Jackson Hole keynote, new chair Kevin Warsh, Fri 28 Aug (theme "Financial Innovation"); BofA survey ~69% expect neutral / ~31% hawkish. 4. Regime: fiscal dominance / debasement bid; Goldman & TD FX-volatility warnings into Jackson Hole; Ed Yardeni "vigilantes stirring"; auction-demand-still-firm counter. Market explanation and education, NOT investment advice; forecasts flagged; no level invented.

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE INVITATION — FILM PHOTOGRAPHY

Thirty-Six Frames, No Screen, and a Wait — the Constraint Is the Whole Product

You load a light-proof roll, get a fixed number of shots, and cannot see a single one until chemistry and a scanner give them back. In a world of infinite free frames, film sells the one thing digital can't: scarcity, deliberation, and a decades-old machine you buy once.

this story  

Film photography is the pursuit of a picture you have to earn. You load a plastic roll coated in light-sensitive emulsion into a mechanical camera, you get thirty-six frames on a standard roll — fewer on the bigger formats — and there is no preview, no delete, no second look until the film is developed and scanned. That constraint is not a bug the hobby tolerates; it is the product it sells. The look helps — grain, halation, the gentle roll-off of colour that people read as warmer than clinical digital — but the deeper draw is the forced slowness and the delayed reveal. For a buy-once reader it matters that the expensive part is durable: the camera is a precision object that often predates him, and the film and the lab work are the consumables.¹

People fall in the same three ways: an inherited or cheaply-bought old SLR whose first roll startles them, the aesthetic seduction of a frame shot on Kodak Portra, or the plain relief of a device that does one thing and never buzzes. And the world they fall into is bigger and better-organised than an outsider expects. The photo-sharing subreddit runs near two-point-seven million members; its technical sister community another three hundred and sixty-five thousand; the veteran forum Photrio, once APUG, some sixty thousand.² The clinching signal that this is not a fad: manufacturers are adding capacity. Kodak's film sales rose about a fifth in 2024, it launched a new consumer colour stock in 2025, and Harman opened a fresh coating line to make more black-and-white — factories do not build for a bubble.³

~2.7M

MEMBERS OF THE MAIN FILM-PHOTOGRAPHY SUBREDDIT; ITS TECHNICAL SISTER SUB ADDS ~365K AND THE VETERAN PHOTRIO FORUM ~60K — A LARGE, ACTIVE, ARGUMENTATIVE WORLD, NOT A NOSTALGIA NICHE

THE CHATTER · FRONTIER OR NORITSU — YOU PICK A LAB BY ITS SCANNER

The first real faction line a newcomer meets is about the scan, not the shot. The community sorts labs by which machine they run: a Fuji Frontier reads bold, contrasty and punchy; a Noritsu reads softer and truer to life, and shooters chase one "look" over the other like a house style. It is the tell that in film, the image is made twice — once in the camera, once at the scanner — and the second time is where most pictures live or die.

Lab-scanner explainers; r/AnalogCommunity consensus (characterised)

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The next two pages descend into all of it: where the community gathers and argues, what the gear actually costs from the sane entry to the over-the-top, the cutting edge of the last twelve months, the jargon and the factions — and the honest sceptic's account of where the money stops buying better pictures and starts buying a story.

SOURCES 1. Casual Photophile / 35mmc — film as a durable-camera, consumable-film hobby; the constraint (36 frames, no preview) as the appeal; the gateway moments. 2. PetaPixel, "Top Photo Communities on Reddit" (Jul 2025) / Wikipedia "Photrio" — r/analog ~2.7M, r/AnalogCommunity ~365k, Photrio (ex-APUG, founded 2002) ~60k. 3. C&EN / market coverage, 2025–26 — Kodak film sales up ~20% in 2024, launched Kodacolor 100/200 (2025); Harman (Ilford) opened a new coating line to expand B&W capacity. (Some market-size dollar figures trace to SEO reports — used only as direction, not printed as fact.)

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE DEEP END — THE GEAR

The Only Company Still Making a New 35mm Rangefinder Charges Seven Thousand Dollars

From a two-hundred-dollar Nikon to a large-format view camera, the film-gear ladder is unusually kind to a buy-once temperament — the bodies are durable and hold value. Then it meets two traps: the Leica tax at the top, and a point-and-shoot bubble in the middle.

Weigh the ladder the way this reader would — toward the quality entry and above, since the cheap student cameras get a line, not a chapter. The sane 35mm entry is a mechanical Nikon (an FM2 or F3) or the late-'90s pro-grade F100, roughly a hundred and fifty to three hundred and fifty dollars used, giving access to fifty years of F-mount glass.¹ Step up and you enter the connoisseur core, the rangefinder — and here sits the hobby's strangest fact: Voigtlander ended its Bessa line and Zeiss its ZM, so Leica is now effectively the only company making a new 35mm film rangefinder at all. It reissued the M6 new in 2022 at five thousand two hundred and ninety-five dollars; after tariff-driven hikes the new M6 and the meterless M-A now list around seven thousand.²

THE GEAR, BY HONEST TIER

Medium format — the buy-once step-up. A bigger negative, a bigger look: the modular Hasselblad 500 C/M (roughly US\$550–1,450 with a lens), the Pentax 67's big-SLR punch (~US\$700–825), the Mamiya 6 and 7 rangefinders (US\$1,500–2,500+). Large format — 4×5 and 8×10 sheet film — is the over-the-top apex: slow, deliberate, unmatched detail.¹

The film itself — and its rising price. Per 35mm roll: Kodak Gold 200 ~US\$9, Portra 400 ~US\$18 (the enthusiast default), Tri-X and Ilford HP5 ~US\$9–12, Ektachrome slide ~US\$24. Kodak has announced hikes of up to forty per cent, driven by silver — the light-sensitive ingredient — roughly doubling across 2025; and Fuji's Pro 400H stays discontinued, the loss the community still mourns.³

Where enthusiasts actually buy. KEH (conservative grading, a 180-day warranty — the "safe" default), MPB (the largest used platform, shows the actual item), Japan Camera Hunter (Bellamy Hunt's Tokyo scouting for the rare and mint), and eBay for the deepest, riskiest inventory. A good repair technician's clean-lubricate-adjust keeps a fifty-year-old body alive — the artisan tier that matters most.¹

US\$7,000

THE NEW LEICA M6 / M-A AFTER 2026'S TARIFF HIKES, UP FROM THE 2022 REISSUE'S US\$5,295 — THE "LEICA TAX," AND THE PRICE OF BEING THE LAST MAKER OF A NEW 35MM RANGEFINDER

The genuinely new is worth naming, because it revived the whole category. The Pentax 17, out in June 2024 at about five hundred dollars, was the first all-new film camera from a major maker in some twenty years — a half-frame compact that shoots forty-eight frames on a twenty-four-exposure roll — and it sold better than Ricoh expected before its lead designer retired and further models were paused, not cancelled.⁴ Alongside it, Mint's Rollei 35AF revived the classic compact with autofocus at nine hundred and ninety-nine dollars, and Harman's Phoenix 200 II (July 2025) proved a historically black-and-white house could ship a redesigned colour emulsion — bought for its "crunchy pastels" character, not as a Portra substitute.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · IS FILM TOO EXPENSIVE? TWO CAMPS, BOTH RIGHT

The community argues this openly. One side points at the arithmetic — Portra plus a lab develop-and-scan runs about thirty-three to thirty-six dollars a roll, roughly a dollar a frame — and calls the hobby genuinely pricey and getting pricier as silver climbs and Fuji exits. The other, voiced by Casual Photophile's James Tocchio, argues the "film is too expensive" panic is "fundamentally flawed" against what people spend on other hobbies. Both are true at once: it is dear per frame, and cheap next to a golf habit. What is not in dispute is that old electronics die — you are buying thirty-to-sixty-year-old machines with no parts — and that scanning is the real bottleneck.

James Tocchio (Casual Photophile);
r/AnalogCommunity cost threads (characterised)

SOURCES 1. DPReview / KEH / Fstoppers, 2025–26 — Nikon FM2/F3/F100 (~US\$150–350 used); used medium format (Hasselblad 500 C/M ~\$536–1,452, Pentax 67 ~\$688–823, Mamiya 6 ~\$1,558–2,071); KEH 180-day warranty; MPB; Japan Camera Hunter (Bellamy Hunt). Used-camera prices are live-market estimates. 2. DPReview / CineD / RangefinderForum — Voigtlander Bessa & Zeiss ZM discontinued (Leica the only new 35mm rangefinder maker); Leica M6 reissued 2022 at US\$5,295, new M6/M-A ~US\$7,000 after 2026 tariff hikes (2026 figure single-sourced — flagged). 3. Pellica / Field Mag / Digital Camera World / PetaPixel, 2025–26 — Gold 200 ~\$9, Portra 400 ~\$18, Tri-X/HP5 ~\$9–12, Ektachrome E100 ~\$24; Kodak hikes up to 40% (silver ~doubled across 2025); Fujifilm Pro 400H remains discontinued. 4. DPReview / PetaPixel / Amateur Photographer / B&H — Pentax 17 (Jun 2024, ~\$500, half-frame; sold above expectations; designer retired, further models paused not cancelled); Rollei 35AF by Mint (US\$999, autofocus); Harman Phoenix 200 II (16 Jul 2025, redesigned colour negative, "crunchy pastels"). Community sentiment attributed to named people/outlets, reported from search-surfaced threads.

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE DEEP END — THE CULTURE & THE ENTRY

A Dollar a Frame, a Dry Cabinet, and the First Ninety Days

The vocabulary, the factions, and the honest cost — plus a real starter path at real prices, the Singapore labs and shops that make it workable, and the point-and-shoot bubble the shooters themselves call absurd.

The culture rewards a small glossary. To *push* or *pull* is to under- or over-develop deliberately, shooting a film off its box speed; *Sunny 16* is the meterless rule of thumb; *latitude* is how much exposure error a film forgives — colour negative a lot, slide almost none; *halation* is the red glow around bright lights; *DSLR scanning* is digitising a negative by photographing it. The factions map onto those terms: the just-shoot-it crowd against the sharpness pixel-peepers, the meter loyalists against the Sunny-16 traditionalists, and the lab-scan tribe against the home-scan converts who invert with Negative Lab Pro.¹ The economics are blunt: an all-in lab roll of premium colour is about thirty-three to thirty-six dollars, roughly a dollar a frame, while developing black-and-white at home drops the recurring cost to a few dollars after a sixty-to-eighty-dollar kit.¹

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS — AN HONEST PATH

Weeks 1-3 · Lurk before you spend. Read Casual Photophile and 35mmc, watch grainydays and Kyle McDougall, and learn Sunny 16 and box speed before buying anything.

Weeks 3-6 · Buy the sane kit. A serviced Nikon FM2/F3 or F100 from KEH (graded, warrantied) at US\$150-350 — or the new-in-box Pentax 17 at ~US\$500 for a warranty and half-frame economy. Then three to five rolls: mix Gold 200, one Portra 400, one HP5. Don't buy a scanner yet; mail the rolls to a lab.

Weeks 6-12 · Shoot, then choose the fork. After five rolls you'll know if it hooks you; then go quality (a rangefinder or medium format) or process (home developing and a DSLR-scan rig). Realistic ninety-day spend, ex-Leica: about US\$300-600.²

~\$1/frame

THE ALL-IN COST OF A LAB-DEVELOPED ROLL OF PREMIUM COLOUR FILM — THE NUMBER THAT SHOCKS NEWCOMERS; HOME-DEVELOPED BLACK-AND-WHITE FALLS TO A FEW DOLLARS A ROLL AFTER THE KIT

In Singapore the practicalities are specific. Whampoa Colour Centre on Balestier Road is the community's

cheap develop-and-buy, with development from around twelve dollars; Peninsula Shopping Centre is the physical hub for bodies and film, with Ruby Photo the local source for bulk rolls. And a dry cabinet is not optional here — at humidity regularly above eighty per cent, cameras and lenses need forty-to-fifty-per-cent storage or they grow fungus, which makes an electronic dry cabinet a genuine buy-once purchase adjacent to the hobby.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE POINT-AND-SHOOT BUBBLE IS MADNESS, AND THEY KNOW IT

The clearest gap between hype and reality is the compact-camera mania. A Contax T2 now clears eight hundred to three thousand dollars, a Yashica T4 five to six hundred — up four to six times since 2019 — and the community itself calls it: Casual Photophile's own T4 review is subtitled "a hype-free review" and pins the price on "celebrity association and social-media hype, not objective superiority." These are fashion objects, not value. The honest cautions beyond them: "film is better" is mostly a myth (it's *different*, not sharper or more convenient), the upgrade treadmill runs from SLR to Leica to medium format, and the least glamorous step — scanning — is where most people's pictures quietly die.

Casual Photophile "hype-free" T4 review; eBay price data (characterised)

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Headphone enthusiasts — IEMs and open-backs, the measurement-versus-ears wars, and the purest buy-once-cry-once audio rabbit hole.

Vinyl records & turntables — the analogue-ritual revival, pressing quality, and the cartridge-and-phono-stage descent.

Fountain pens — ink chemistry, grail nibs, and the slow-writing revival for the analogue-minded.

SOURCES 1. Light Leaks / Negative Supply / Vintage Visual — glossary (push/pull, Sunny 16, latitude, halation, DSLR scanning, box speed); Frontier-vs-Noritsu and meter-vs-Sunny-16 factions; Negative Lab Pro for home inversion; lab roll ~US\$33-36 all-in (Portra ~\$18 + dev-and-scan ~\$15-18); home B&W ~\$1-4/roll after a ~\$60-80 kit. 2. KEH / DPReview — starter path: Nikon FM2/F3/F100 (US\$150-350) or Pentax 17 (~US\$500); 3-5 rolls (Gold/Portra/HP5); ~US\$300-600 realistic 90-day spend ex-Leica. 3. TheSmartLocal / drycabinets.com.sg — Whampoa Colour Centre (dev from ~\$12, Balestier), Peninsula Shopping Centre hub (Ruby Photo for bulk rolls); SG humidity >80% RH, storage 40-50% RH, dry cabinets standard to prevent fungus. 4. Casual Photophile "Yashica T4 — a hype-free review" / eBay data — Contax T2 ~US\$800-3,000, Yashica T4 ~US\$500-600 (up 4-6× since 2019), priced on "hype, not objective superiority"; the money pits and the scanning bottleneck. Used-market prices are live estimates; community sentiment attributed to named outlets.

FITNESS • THE LONG GAME

The Strength Dose With a Ceiling: Ninety Minutes Buys the Longevity, and More Buys Nothing

A thirty-year study of nearly a hundred and fifty thousand people found the sweet spot for lifting sits at ninety to a hundred and twenty minutes a week — and, unusually, that the benefit flatlines above it. Two fifty-minute sessions is the high-return dose; the medal for overtraining doesn't exist.

this story  

The useful number this month has a ceiling built in. A Harvard-led study in the British Journal of Sports Medicine, published in June and tracking 147,374 people for about three decades, put the strength-training longevity sweet spot at ninety to a hundred and twenty minutes a week: thirteen per cent lower all-cause mortality, nineteen per cent lower cardiovascular death, twenty-seven per cent lower death from neurological disease — with no additional benefit above two hours.¹ The combination beat either half alone; pairing resistance work with a solid aerobic block cut the death-risk association by about forty-five per cent. For a mid-forties reader, the translation is almost annoyingly simple: two fifty-minute lifting sessions a week, plus your cardio, is the high-return dose, and grinding past it is ego, not medicine.

90–120

MINUTES OF STRENGTH TRAINING A WEEK, THE LONGEVITY SWEET SPOT IN THE 147,374-PERSON STUDY — 13% LOWER ALL-CAUSE AND 27% LOWER NEUROLOGICAL-DISEASE MORTALITY, AND NO EXTRA BENEFIT PAST TWO HOURS

Two supporting findings sharpen it. A May analysis found the strongest-grip group carried a roughly thirty-three per cent lower death risk, independent of aerobic activity — strength as a standalone longevity marker, not just a gym vanity.² And the cardio side of the ledger stays dominant: Peter Attia's much-cited figure has moving from the bottom quartile of cardiorespiratory fitness to above-average associated with about a seventy per cent lower all-cause mortality — the single largest modifiable lever

there is.³ The shape of the mid-forties programme writes itself from those three numbers: defend the engine, build the strength, and stop chasing volume that the data says does nothing.

THE CHATTER • RUCKING AND THE VO2MAX GOSPEL

The Attia-Huberman corner of the discourse has converged on two ideas the reader keeps hearing: VO2max as "the most important health number you've never heard of," and rucking — walking under load on hilly terrain — as a joint-friendly way to bank Zone-2 minutes with a strength stimulus attached. The running-forum counter-debate, "is Zone 2 overhyped," rumbles alongside it. The signal under the noise is consistent with the studies: build the aerobic base and the strength, and don't over-engineer the middle.

Peter Attia / Huberman Lab community
(characterised)

THE SCEPTIC • ZONE 2 ISN'T THE MAGIC BULLET

A Singapore GP, Dr Samuel Choudhury, wrote the useful corrective this year: Zone 2 is necessary but oversold, the time-crunched often get more cardiorespiratory return from brief high-intensity work, and the cohort associations behind all of this are not proof of causation.⁴ It pairs cleanly with the strength study's own honest edge — the "no benefit above 120 minutes" finding is itself a warning against more-is-better. Read the numbers as a floor to clear and a ceiling to respect, not a prescription. General information, not medical advice.

Dr Samuel Choudhury (drsamuelgp.com), May 2026
(characterised)

SOURCES 1. British Journal of Sports Medicine / Harvard Health / ScienceDaily (11 Jun 2026) — 147,374 people, ~30 yrs; strength-training sweet spot 90–120 min/wk (13% lower all-cause, 19% CV, 27% neurological-disease mortality), no benefit above 120 min; resistance + aerobic combined ~45% lower death-risk association. 2. ScienceDaily (May 2026) — highest grip-strength group ~33% lower mortality, independent of aerobic activity. 3. Peter Attia MD — bottom-quartile → above-average cardiorespiratory fitness (VO2max) ~70% lower all-cause mortality. 4. Dr Samuel Choudhury (drsamuelgp.com, May 2026) — Zone 2 necessary but oversold; time-crunched get more from brief high-intensity; cohort associations are not causation. Fitness items are general information, not medical advice.

THE DIARY · WHAT'S WORTH BOOKING

A Sprint-Weekend Grand Prix, a Stadium Autumn, and a Kyushu Sumo Run Worth the Flight

The dated agenda through year-end — Singapore's first-ever Formula One Sprint, a dense run of arena nights, and the Tokyo and regional fixtures a Japan-loving family should book now, with the twelve-year-old's picks flagged.

this story  

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 9–11 Oct**
★ F1 Singapore Airlines Grand Prix
 MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT · THE SEASON'S FIRST-EVER SINGAPORE SPRINT ON SATURDAY · ZONE-4 WALKABOUT GA FROM ~\$198/DAY · EARLY-BIRD GONE, BOOK ZONES NOW · FAMILY-OK (WALKABOUT)
- 3 Oct**
ITZY — "Tunnel Vision"
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · K-POP · TEEN-FRIENDLY
- 11–12 Oct**
TWICE — World Tour
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · ~\$168–398 · TWO NIGHTS
- 18–19 Oct**
NCT Dream
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · SELLS OUT FAST
- 4 Nov**
LANY
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · VIA TICKETMASTER
- 10–11 Nov**
My Chemical Romance
 INDOOR STADIUM · FIRST RETURN IN 17 YEARS · RESCHEDULED FROM APR · SKEWS OLDER
- 21–22 Nov**
Guns N' Roses
 SINGAPORE EXPO ARENA · THE STADIUM-ROCK MARQUEE
- 28–29 Nov**
BABYMONSTER — "CHOOM" Tour
 K-POP · A SOLID PICK FOR A 12-YEAR-OLD

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

- 8–22 Nov**
★ Grand Sumo — Kyushu Basho
 FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · TICKETS ON SALE 19 SEP (SELL OUT ON RELEASE DAY) · MATINEE BOUTS ARE VERY FAMILY-FRIENDLY
- 29 Oct–23 Nov**
Night Tempo — "Showa Groove"
 MULTIPLE CITIES · CITY-POP REVIVAL · ADVANCE ¥5,500 (TOKYO ¥6,000)
- 8 Nov**
Death Cab for Cutie
 MATSUSHITA IMP HALL, OSAKA
- 28 Nov**
Queens of the Stone Age
 ZEPP NAMBA, OSAKA
- 3 Nov**
Melbourne Cup
 FLEMINGTON · AUSTRALIA'S MARQUEE RACE DAY
- 26 Dec**
Boxing Day Test
 MCG, MELBOURNE · THE SUMMER'S SET-PIECE

PLANNING NOTES · TIMING & SELL-OUTS

Book the Sprint zones now. The F1 early-bird is gone, and with the first-ever Sprint making Saturday a full race day, the three-day pass is better value this year — sort sightlines before the grandstands thin.¹ **Kyushu sumo is the release-day scramble:** tickets drop on the nineteenth of September and famously sell out that day, so buy the moment they open via the official channel.² **One to hold:** the K-pop arena nights (TWICE, NCT Dream) move fast — set a Ticketmaster alert rather than deciding on the night.

GOOD FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD

Four genuine family picks at her age: the Sprint's walkabout zones, a BABYMONSTER night for the K-pop fan, the short, dramatic bouts and matinee sessions of Kyushu sumo, and Night Tempo's all-ages city-pop show. The stadium rock nights (My Chemical Romance, Guns N' Roses) skew older; the Melbourne Cup and Boxing Day Test are travel-and-spectacle days for the whole family.

SOURCES 1. Wego / Honeycombers / Songkick / Harper's Bazaar SG, Aug 2026 — F1 Singapore GP 9–11 Oct (first-ever Sprint; Zone-4 Walkabout GA from ~\$198/day; early-bird closed); ITZY 3 Oct; TWICE 11–12 Oct (~\$168–398); NCT Dream 18–19 Oct; LANY 4 Nov; My Chemical Romance 10–11 Nov (return after 17 years); Guns N' Roses 21–22 Nov (Expo Arena); BABYMONSTER 28–29 Nov. 2. selfguidejapan / BuySumoTickets / Tokyo Cheapo / Songkick Osaka, 2026 — Grand Sumo Kyushu Basho 8–22 Nov (Fukuoka; tickets on sale 19 Sep, sell out on release day); Night Tempo "Showa Groove" tour 29 Oct–23 Nov (advance ¥5,500 / Tokyo ¥6,000); Death Cab for Cutie 8 Nov & QOTSA 28 Nov (Osaka); Melbourne Cup 3 Nov; Boxing Day Test 26 Dec (MCG). ArtScience/National Gallery family exhibitions flagged but run-dates unconfirmed — held.

THE DIARY • THE TABLE — SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

A One-Michelin Chef's Cheaper Room, a Paris Café Flagship, and a CBD Bakery Worth the Detour

Three genuinely new tables — one the most accessible way yet into a starred kitchen, two brand imports where the pedigree is real but the verdict is still forming.

Lead with the pedigree pick. Assaggi opened on the tenth of August at 77A Neil Road, from Denis Lucchi — the chef behind one-Michelin Buona Terra — and it is, by design, the most affordable way into his cooking. The format is tasting-menu-only, "flavour over form": a three-course lunch at fifty-eight dollars-plus-plus, and two "Journey" dinner menus, Signature and Pasta, at eighty-eight each, with cocktails from the adjoining Bar Kakure.¹ The early word from the local food desks is warm — an accessible, wallet-friendlier Lucchi — with the honest dissent being the set-menu-only format and a compact room that caps spontaneity. Book dinner ahead; the seating is small and it runs Tuesday to Saturday.

The two imports are where the pedigree outpaces the verdict. Maison PAUL, at Paragon, is the French bakery-café's first Singapore flagship concept, with an exclusive dine-in menu alongside the pâtisserie counter — a polished arrival, but a chain flagship rather than a new idea, so treat the hype accordingly.² And Mimmo Bakery, in Asia Square Tower 1 on the Shenton Way stretch, brings French and Italian pastries crossed with Hong-Kong-inspired flavours to the CBD lunch crowd — a promising neighbourhood addition whose real test is whether the quality holds once the opening-week queue thins.²

The through-line across all three is worth stating plainly: one is a genuine destination, and two are brand arrivals riding opening buzz. None has a settled critical verdict yet, which is exactly why this desk grades them "promising," not "proven."

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE EARLY WORD SAYS

Assaggi carries the most consensus — the food media frame it as the value route into Lucchi's cooking, with the set-menu caveat noted rather than dismissed. Maison PAUL and Mimmo are running ahead of the reviews: heavy on brand recognition, light on long-form critic verdicts. Read all three as anticipation, not judgement — the same standard this desk holds everything to.

Time Out SG / HungryGoWhere / The Ranting Panda / Eatbook, Aug 2026

THE SCEPTIC • A FLAGSHIP IS NOT A VERDICT

The honest caution on the two imports: a global bakery's first local flagship sells the name before it earns the plate, and an opening-week CBD queue is buying novelty as much as pastry. Neither is a knock — both may be very good — but don't mistake a launch for a considered judgement. Assaggi is the one with genuine kitchen pedigree, and even there the tasting-only format is a real constraint on how often you'd go back.

Opening coverage (characterised), Aug 2026

JUST OPENED

TOO NEW TO CALL

ONE-MICHELIN PEDIGREE

BOOK AHEAD

THE BOOKING CALCULUS

Timing the three. Assaggi's small room is the one to reserve — take the S\$58++ lunch as the value entry into a starred chef's cooking. Maison PAUL and Mimmo are walk-in, photo-first openings, so go off-peak and let the queue, not the hype, decide whether they're worth a second visit.

Rotated off, still trading. Last issue's four — the Labubu bakery at Sentosa, Tembusu in the Botanic Gardens, the Michelin-starred Sushi Ryujiro and the National Gallery's Xava Skybar — are all now open. This desk moves on rather than re-listing them, but for a guaranteed table this month, a reviewed opening beats an unproven one.

SOURCES 1. The Ranting Panda / HungryGoWhere / FACT, Aug 2026 — Assaggi, 77A Neil Road, opened 10 Aug; chef Denis Lucchi (1-Michelin Buona Terra); tasting-menu-only; lunch S\$58++ (3-course), dinner "Signature Journey" & "Pasta Journey" S\$88++; Bar Kakure cocktails; Tue-Sat; early word warm, set-menu format the noted dissent. 2. Time Out SG / Eatbook / Daniel Food Diary, Aug 2026 — Maison PAUL, Paragon (PAUL's first SG flagship café concept, exclusive dine-in menu — chain flagship, flagged); Mimmo Bakery, Asia Square Tower 1 (French/Italian pastries + HK-inspired flavours, CBD). All flagged too new for a settled verdict. Rotated off No. 81's Table (Labubu Bakery, Tembusu, Sushi Ryujiro, Xava Skybar) and No. 80's (City Bakery, Charcoal Grill Shinpachi).

THE UNDERCURRENT • VIETNAM

The People's Central Bank

Across Vietnam, young office workers are turning payday into gold day — buying bullion by the tenth-of-a-*tael* on their phones and queuing in the rain for mini-bars. It reads like a savings-app story. Look again: a generation is quietly building its own gold-backed pension, exactly as the state races to take that gold back.

this story  

There is a phrase doing quiet work across Vietnamese social media: *tích lũy vàng*, accumulating gold. It has become a personal-finance genre — creators framing a monthly gold purchase as adult discipline, the way another country's twenty-somethings might frame an index fund. And the numbers behind the mood are real. In late January the benchmark SJC gold bar hit an all-time high of about a hundred and ninety million dong a *tael* — some seven thousand two hundred US dollars for thirty-seven and a half grams — carrying a stubborn premium over the world price.¹ By the lunar God of Wealth Day in late February, with prices near two hundred million a *tael*, buyers were queuing two and three hours in the rain on Hanoi's gold streets, and teenagers were buying slivers of a tenth of a *tael* just to keep the luck-and-savings ritual alive.³

Tích lũy vàng — accumulating gold. In another country the same twenty-somethings would call it an index fund.

The scale is not a fad's. A World Gold Council survey found that among Vietnamese aged eighteen to thirty-four, seventy-four per cent want vaulted gold, seventy-six per cent want a gold investment account, and forty-eight per cent would buy it through a digital platform.² Fintechs have rushed the gap: apps like HanaGold sell fractional grams from a hundred thousand dong — about four US dollars — pitched squarely at savers "with limited funds." It is the local echo of China's "gold beans," and it reframes a wedding heirloom as a Gen-Z habit. J. P. Morgan's old line — that gold is money and everything else is credit — is being tested, one sliver at a time, by the

people who are supposed to be modern finance's future customers.

74%

OF VIETNAMESE AGED 18–34 WHO SAY THEY WANT VAULTED GOLD, PER A WORLD GOLD COUNCIL SURVEY — WITH 76% WANTING A GOLD INVESTMENT ACCOUNT AND 48% WILLING TO BUY IT THROUGH AN APP

The behaviour is disciplined, not frenzied. When gold and silver plunged some ten per cent over two days in late January, the crowds bought the dip rather than panic-selling, and the fractional-gold apps report their fastest growth among savers "with limited funds" who accumulate a hundred thousand dong at a time.³ The mood the World Gold Council and the local press describe is defensive optimism — not "I'll get rich," but "at least this won't disappear." It is the same instinct that filled glass jars with one-gram gold beans across China, arriving now in a country whose grandparents actually watched paper money evaporate.

Not "I'll get rich," but "at least this won't disappear." In Vietnam right now, the savviest fintech is a metal bar.

And the scale keeps compounding. Vietnam is the second-largest gold-bar buyer in Southeast Asia, and the digital rails are pulling in exactly the savers a bank would once have captured — young, salaried, and increasingly convinced that a gram of gold is a safer monthly deposit than any product the formal system is selling them. That conviction is what the next two pages follow: what the state is now doing about it, and why the instinct is far older than any app.

SOURCES 1. VnEconomy, "Gold prices in Vietnam hit all-time high" — SJC gold ~190.3m VND (~US\$7,235)/*tael*, 29 Jan 2026; persistent domestic premium over world price. 2. World Gold Council retail insights (Vietnam) — among 18–34s: 74% want vaulted gold, 76% a gold investment account, 48% would buy via a digital platform. 3. Vietnam News, "God of Wealth Day sparks gold rush," 26 Feb 2026 — 2–3-hour queues, prices near 200m VND/*tael*, teens buying 0.1-*tael* mini-bars; HanaGold "4.0 gold shop" fractional grams from 100,000 VND (~US\$4). Figures reported via named outlets; treat as attributed, not independently re-confirmed.

The irony that makes this a policy story, not a lifestyle one, is that the state wants the same gold — badly. On the twenty-sixth of August last year, Decree 232 ended the state-and-SJC monopoly on gold-bar production and raw-gold trade that had ruled since 2012, and imports reopened for the first time in about a decade; the prime minister then ordered a national gold exchange fast-tracked toward early 2026, with new commodity-exchange rules taking effect in September.¹ The goal is explicit: coax the hoard into the formal system. Official estimates put more than five hundred tonnes of gold sitting idle in private hands — a bottleneck the government wants mobilised into banks and markets rather than buried in drawers.¹

The central bank's nightmare word is goldisation. It is de-goldising precisely because the young are re-goldising.

Here is the collision in one line: the central bank's nightmare word is "goldisation" — mass hoarding that weakens confidence in the dong and hobbles monetary policy — and it is de-goldising precisely because the young are re-goldising. The scarcity is visible in the data. Vietnam bought about thirty-six tonnes of gold bar and bullion in 2025, second in Southeast Asia, yet that was down roughly a seventh on the year, and the World Gold Council pinned the fall on a domestic supply shortage rather than fading appetite.² The queues, in other words, are not exuberance meeting supply; they are hunger meeting scarcity.

Put a face on it and the instinct is unmistakable. A Hanoi office worker the wire services found, "Huong," takes a half-day off every month to queue on Tran Nhan Tong street and buy a little gold — "my efforts have paid off," she says. Another, Phan Thi Minh Anh,

twenty-eight, moved her savings out of a bank account and into gold, buying small amounts whenever she has spare cash.³ This is not speculation in the day-trading sense; it is defensive, patient, and oddly conservative — a monthly deposit into an asset that, whatever else happens, will still be there. To a government watching youth unemployment sit near seventeen per cent, a generation that converts wages into metal is both a signal and a problem: a vote of no-confidence in the savings products the formal economy offers.

500+ tonnes

THE GOLD OFFICIALS ESTIMATE SITS IDLE IN VIETNAMESE PRIVATE HANDS — THE HOARD THE NEW NATIONAL EXCHANGE IS DESIGNED TO PULL INTO THE FORMAL FINANCIAL SYSTEM, AND THE MEASURE OF HOW LITTLE THE YOUNG TRUST IT

The supply squeeze is the government's own policy catching up with it. For over a decade the state monopoly kept the SJC bar the only game in town, and the stubborn premium of the domestic price over the world price — running to the equivalent of hundreds of dollars a tael — was the visible cost of that closed system.¹ Ending the monopoly and reopening imports is meant to narrow that gap by letting more metal in; the national exchange is meant to give the hoard somewhere formal to live. Whether either can outrun a generation's appetite is the open question the whole reform hangs on.

Underneath the queues sits the real driver: a savings market this cohort does not trust. Youth unemployment near seventeen per cent, a property ladder pulled up, a corporate-bond scare still fresh, and an equity market few young savers will touch — set against a currency their family history taught them to distrust — leaves gold as the rational default. It is not exuberance. It is the considered verdict of savers who have run out of alternatives they believe in, and who have decided the safest financial technology in the country is the one their grandmother used.

SOURCES 1. Vietnam+ / SGGP, 2025–26 — Decree 232/2025/ND-CP (26 Aug 2025) ended the state/SJC bullion monopoly (in force since 2012); imports reopened Oct 2025; national gold exchange fast-tracked toward Feb 2026; Decree 302 commodity-exchange rules effective 15 Sep 2026; official estimates of 500+ tonnes of privately-held gold; central-bank "goldisation" warnings. 2. World Gold Council via vietnam.vn / VnExpress — Vietnam ~36.1t bar/bullion demand 2025 (2nd in SE Asia behind Thailand's 51.4t), down ~14% on 2024, attributed to a domestic supply shortage, not falling appetite. 3. AFP ("Heavy metal..." ~30 Jan 2026) / Vietnam News — "Huong" queues monthly on Tran Nhan Tong street; Phan Thi Minh Anh (28) shifted savings from a bank into gold. Youth-unemployment context ~17%. Figures reported/attributed; treat as as-reported.

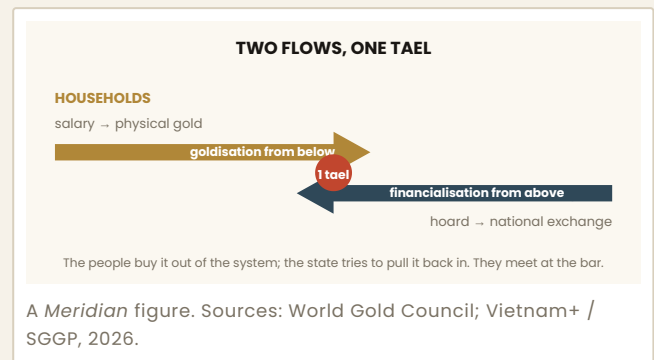
To see why this is a grandchildren's story, look at the grandparents. Vietnam's post-war inflation peaked at roughly eight hundred and seventy-five per cent in 1986; a 1985 currency revaluation wiped nine-tenths off the dong's value, and by the late eighties houses, motorbikes and livestock were priced and traded in gold taels because paper had stopped meaning anything.¹ The survival reflex of that generation is resurfacing in one that never lived it — and today's "gold-for-property" schemes, now drawing legal scrutiny, are a near-literal replay. The nearer precedent is next door: China's "gold beans," one-gram pieces bought monthly "like milk tea" and hoarded in glass bottles by young savers through 2023 and 2024, a craze the Western press eventually wrote up.² Vietnam is the obvious next chapter of that story, which is exactly why it belongs here before the FT gets to it.

Everyone is hedging the same loss of faith — from Hanoi twenty-somethings to the central banks that have bought gold in record tonnage.

The cleanest way to read it is as a mirror. Central banks have spent three years stockpiling gold at record pace to hedge their distrust of the dollar system; Vietnam's young are doing at the household scale exactly what sovereigns do at the national one. Everyone, from a twenty-something on Tran Nhan Tong street to the People's Bank, is quietly hedging the same loss of faith in paper promises. The state's push for a national exchange is the attempt to turn that private hedge into public liquidity — to make the drawer-gold bankable.

The gold-for-property schemes now drawing legal scrutiny are the sharpest echo of the 1980s, when a home changed hands for a weight of gold rather than a stack of dong — a workaround people reinvent whenever they stop believing the currency will hold its value between the handshake and the deed. That the young are reaching for the same instrument their

grandparents used is not nostalgia; it is a rational response to the same underlying fear, wearing a savings app instead of hidden under a floorboard.



The newest risk is the one the reform is meant to cure. The apps that put a hundred thousand dong of bullion on a phone screen also put that money in a platform's promise to redeem it — and Vietnamese analyses have pointed to a Shenzhen digital-gold platform reportedly collapsing early this year when investors could not cash out (a claim this desk flags as unverified). A hedge against paper that lives inside an app has quietly reinvented the counterparty risk it was supposed to escape.

A hedge against paper that lives inside an app has quietly reinvented the counterparty risk it was meant to escape.

The counter-read keeps the piece honest. They may be buying the top — gold at all-time highs, a stubborn local premium, and mark-ups on small novelty pieces mean many young savers overpay, and the fractional-gold apps carry their own fraud risk, not less. The soberest objection is the deepest: this is not rebellion but the oldest, most conservative instinct there is, and a cohort parking its future in an unproductive metal is the symptom of a broken savings market, not a clever hedge. That is the argument under the queue. When the credit looks shaky, people reach for the thing they can hold — and a country where the young are doing it by the sliver is telling you something about the credit.

SOURCES 1. Great American Coin Co / SBMA / Tulane (Vietnam gold history) — post-war inflation peak ~875% (1986); 1985 "new dong" revaluation wiped ~9/10 of the currency's value; late-1980s houses/motorbikes/livestock priced in gold taels. Vietnam News — "gold-for-property" schemes under legal scrutiny, 2026. 2. Bloomberg (16 Mar 2024) / Nikkei Asia / MINING.com — China "gold beans" (1g, ¥400–600, bought monthly "like milk tea"), youth-unemployment/deflation-driven; 10–30% over spot on small pieces, fake risk. 3. World Gold Council central-bank surveys — record sovereign gold buying, 2022–26, hedging distrust of the dollar system. All figures reported/attributed; the essay's numbers are drawn from search-surfaced summaries and flagged as as-reported.

J. P. Morgan told a hostile committee in 1912 that gold is money and everything else is credit, and this issue is a set of variations on that one distinction. A bond market discovered that even the richest borrower on earth cannot make credit behave — the long yield hit a nineteen-year high, and the Treasury had to rescue its own market before the debasement bid ran to a record in gold. Half a world away, young Vietnamese reached the same conclusion with their salaries, buying bullion by the sliver as a private pension while their government scrambled to pull that hoard back into the formal system. And the instinct scaled all the way down to the quiet desks: a sheet chosen for the cloth and not the label, a camera bought once and kept for thirty years, a watch that runs on light and never needs a battery. Credit is a promise about the future; the things people reach for when the promise looks thin are the things they can hold in their hands. This week, from a Vietnamese gold street to a nineteen-year high in the American long bond, a great many people were quietly checking which of the two they trusted.

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